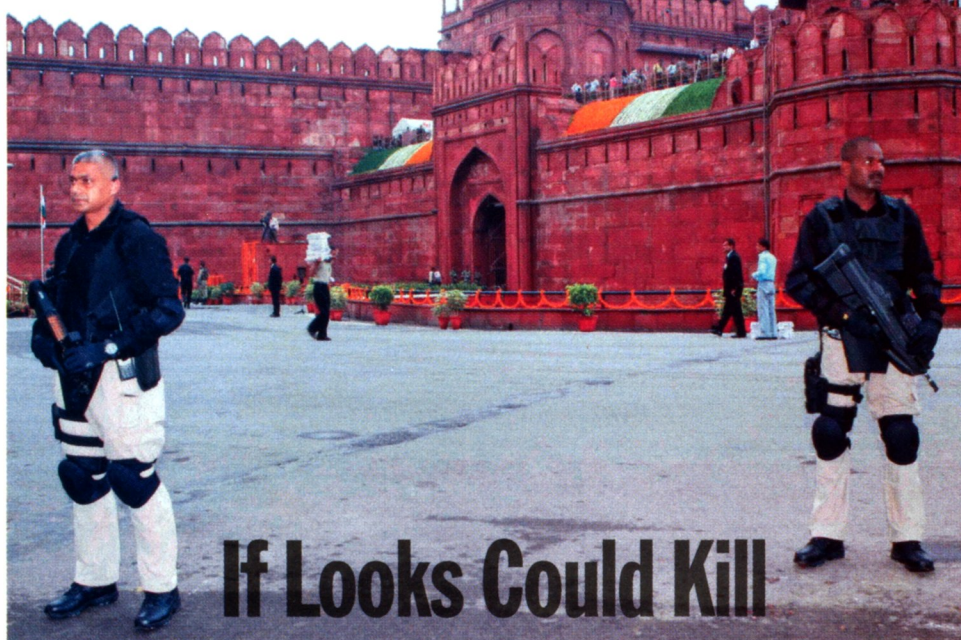


COMBAT READY: The counter-assault team with its new weaponry



SIPRA DAS

SPG weapons like the venerable Uzi, MP-5 sub-machine guns and Glock pistols with Belgian arms maker FN Herstal products—the 'Five Seven' pistol, the P-90 sub-machine gun and FN 2000 Tactical Assault Rifle.

SPG officials say the force, first introduced by the US Secret Service, was specially trained and fielded after threat perceptions of attacks by heavily armed, bullet-proof jacket-wearing desperadoes. The 5.7x28 mm armour-piercing ammunition fired by the P-90 pistol can deal with such threats.

In the pipeline are special armoured cars for the force. The SPG will get its own wings—four of 12 VIP triple-engined helicopters being contracted from Italy's Augusta-Westland at a cost of Rs 110 crore each. Who said protecting the chief executive came cheap.

by Sandeep Unnithan

DELHI The Special Protection Group (SPG)—that exclusively protects the prime minister, Congress President Sonia Gandhi and former prime ministers—unveiled a new sub-unit on Independence Day. As its 'principal'

(bodyguard-speak for the protectee) delivered the traditional address from the ramparts of the Red Fort, the SPG's new counter-assault force stood guard below.

The force is meant to withstand and repel heavy

fire assaults even as the SPG's proximate protection whisks the prime minister away to safety. It is equipped with body armour capable of withstanding AK-47 rounds. The counter-assault force has replaced traditional

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

The fact that many of the bureaucrats handling Kashmir and internal security got consistently low grades—some as low as 2/10—in their confidential reports may explain why things are going from bad to worse on both fronts.

VOICES

“After the assassination of my mother (Benazir Bhutto), I had said that democracy is the best revenge. Indeed, democracy is the greatest revenge.”

Billawal Bhutto, Pakistan People's Party chairman

“I will never compromise on people's movement. I am ready to shed blood rather than bow my head. Without return of the land (in Singur) there will be no talks.”

Mamata Banerjee, Trinamool Congress chief

“CPI(M) is carrying on a misleading campaign on the Indo-US nuclear deal that the Government has sacrificed the country's sovereignty, which is utterly false.”

Pranab Mukherjee, external affairs minister

“The Muslim leadership has not bothered to clear the air about what Islam actually is.”

Shabana Azmi, actor and former MP

“Dreams are not those you get while sleeping. Dreams are those that don't let you sleep.”

Akhil Kumar, pugilist at the Beijing Olympics